

Understanding

What is that? — Is that what we seek?

I shall not today attempt further to define the kinds of material. . . embraced within that shorthand definition. . . . But I know it when I see it.

Potter Stewart, Supreme Court Associate Justice, *Jacobellis vs. Ohio*, 1964.

Understanding is a subjective concept that is almost undefinable. It is being able to grasp all sides and all levels of a problem simultaneously. It is not the same as having a theory, because

- You can intuitively understand something without being able to formalize it.
- You can have a theory that you don't understand!

Understanding might be regarded as knowing the *meaning* of a theory.

Arguably understanding is not the end point of science, just a means to the end.

Understanding aids the construction of new theories. . . and better models.